Every Day Written Out: Eleven Bullocks and the Weekdays the Torah Refused to Summarize

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On Monday, 28 September 2026 (17 Tishrei 5787), the third day of Sukkot, the Musaf of the Temple would have brought eleven bullocks. "On the third day: eleven bullocks, two rams, fourteen yearling lambs without blemish" (Bamidbar 29:20). On the fourth day, ten. The count goes down by one each day until the seventh.

What strikes me every year is not the arithmetic. It is the way the Torah writes it.

A paragraph for every day

The Torah could have said it in a single sentence: begin with thirteen bullocks and bring one fewer each day for seven days. It does not. It writes out each day in full. The first day, then "on the second day," then "on the third day," and so on, each with its own bullocks, rams, lambs, its own meal offerings and libations, and its own goat for atonement (Bamidbar 29:12–34).

The paragraphs are nearly identical. A reader skimming would think they were copies. But the Torah, which elsewhere compresses whole generations into a verse, gives each day of this festival its own paragraph.

I think this says something about the days we are living now. Chol HaMoed can feel like a blur. The first day had its drama of arrival, and the last days have Hoshana Rabbah and Shemini Atzeret. The days between run together: trips, meals, errands, the sukkah in the evening. The Torah will not let them run together. Each one is named. Each one has its own offering.

Small differences that carry meaning

The Sages noticed that the nearly identical paragraphs are not quite identical. Rashi, citing the tradition, points out that in three of the days the Torah changes one word slightly. On the second day it writes *veniskeihem*, on the sixth *unesacheha*, on the seventh *kemishpatam*. The extra letters are *mem*, *yud*, *mem*: together, *mayim*, water. From this the Sages found a hint in the written Torah for the water libation of Sukkot (Rashi on Bamidbar 29:18, citing Sifrei and Shabbat 103b).

Whatever one makes of the method, the lesson for a reader is clear. When the Torah repeats itself, the repetition is not filler. A letter in the middle of an ordinary paragraph can carry the secret of the whole festival. The same is true of ordinary days. Something hidden may be written into an ordinary weekday that no one will notice unless they read it slowly.

The weekday as its own offering

We have no altar today, but we still say the Musaf of each day, and in it we name that day's offering. On the morning of 28 September 2026 we said: on the third day, eleven bullocks. We did not say "the usual." We said the number.

That is the discipline of Chol HaMoed. Not every day is a peak, and it is not meant to be. But each day is counted, and each is brought. The ordinary weekday of the festival is not a gap between holy moments. It is one of the holy moments, with its own paragraph in the Torah.

A small practice for today: before the day slips away, name what it held. One conversation in the sukkah worth remembering. One guest. One quiet moment under the schach. Write it down if you can. The Torah wrote down every day of this festival; we can write down one.

For the table

1. The Musaf offering of the third day of Sukkot in the Temple was eleven bullocks.
2. The Torah writes every day of Sukkot out in full, not in one summary.
3. Three tiny spelling changes in those paragraphs spell *mayim*, water.

Sources

- Bamidbar 29:12–34 (the offerings of each day of Sukkot); Bamidbar 29:20 (the third day)
- Rashi on Bamidbar 29:18, citing Sifrei and Shabbat 103b (the letters *mem*, *yud*, *mem*)

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